

PLANT PEST



Karla Salp, Washington State Department of Agriculture, Bugwood.org.

Spongy moth

Exotic to Australia

Features: Medium sized moths that infest and destroy many kinds of plants; large hairy caterpillars up to 7 cm long, with distinctive red and blue spots. They have formerly been referred to as 'gypsy' moths.

Where they're from: Asia, Europe, North Africa, North America

How they spread: Imported nursery stock, freight, cargo ships, containers

At risk: More than 1000 plant species including eucalypts and pine forests, fruit and nut trees

This pest is listed on both the National Priority Plant Pests and the [National Priority List of Exotic Environmental Pests, Weeds and Diseases](#) as it has the potential for significant plant industry/agriculture impacts and may also cause significant damage to our environment and social amenity.

Australian Chief Plant Protection Officer, Dr Gabrielle Vivian-Smith, provides an overview of the risks posed by spongy moth.

Gypsy moths (this species is now referred to as the spongy moth) are destructive pests of forest and horticulture.

They attack more than a thousand species of plants, including fruit and nut trees, plantation forests, native species and ornamental trees.

They breed quickly, laying egg masses that contain between 500-1000 eggs.

Large hairy caterpillars up to 7 cm long with distinctive red and blue spots emerge from the eggs.

These caterpillars are able to completely defoliate trees causing them to die.

If gypsy moth species were to establish into Australia they would be extremely difficult and expensive to manage.

It would cause many impacts for our farmers, our foresters, our gardeners and our natural environment.

Gypsy moths could hitchhike to Australia aboard cargo ships.

These moths attach their egg masses to the sides of ships and containers.

If they were to arrive, Asian gypsy moths present a greater risk of spread because the adult moths can fly up to 40km before mating.

The freshly hatched larvae can also spin silk threads allowing them to drift on air currents up to 10 km if weather conditions are right.

Thanks to the strength of our biosecurity system, Australia remains free of this devastating pest. So, keep a look out for the Asian gypsy moth and keep Australia safe.

Keep it out

Spongy moth species (*Lymatria* spp.) are destructive pests of forests and horticulture that are present in many areas of the world. They attack more than 1000 species of plants including fruit and nut trees, plantation forests, native species and ornamental trees. They breed quickly, laying egg masses that contain 100 – 1200 eggs. Large populations of caterpillars able to completely defoliate trees causing them to die.

The moths lay yellow egg masses on hard surfaces, usually tree trunks but also on logs, outdoor furniture, nursery stock, pallets, shipping containers and on the hulls and rigging of ships. This makes them good at hitchhiking around the world. Locally they can fly, but some also spread as larvae on silk threads.

If a spongy moth species established in Australia they would be extremely difficult and expensive to manage, and would cause problems for many farmers, foresters, threaten our natural environment and impact our gardens.

Importing goods

To keep spongy moths out of Australia, never ignore Australia's strict biosecurity rules.

Import shipments may need to be treated and certified, so before you import, check our [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#).

What to look for

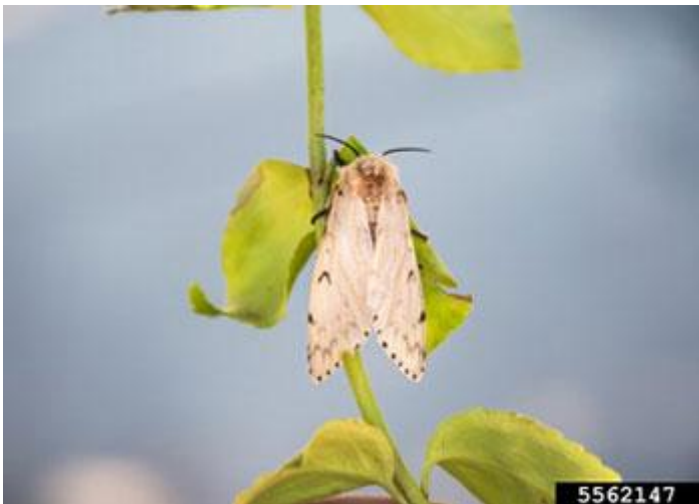
A spongy moth would be most likely to enter Australia in the egg stage. Look for dark yellow egg masses on:

- cargo ships
- commodities
- containers
- freight
- nursery stock
- plant parts
- vehicles.

The flight season (July – September) until hatching time (April – May) is the most likely time when eggs could enter Australia.

Also look out for the pest in the caterpillar stage, when it is large (up to 7 cm long) dark and hairy with two distinctive rows of blue and red raised spots along the back.

As moths, adult males are grey-brown with a wingspan of 3-4 cm and females are pale yellow with wavy dark brown bands and a larger wingspan of 4-7 cm.



Where to look

Importers

If you work around imported goods you need to look for spongy moths or their egg masses attached to:

- planes
- commodities
- freight
- nursery stock
- shipping containers
- vehicles
- vessels.

Growers and home gardeners

Look out for egg masses, caterpillars and moths on trees including:

- eucalypts
- fruit trees
- rose
- timber
- birch
- hemlock
- pines
- spruces
- oak
- ornamental plants.

Damage to crops

Spongy moths target:

- forestry
- nursery
- fruit
- nuts.

What to do

If you think you've found spongy moth:

- take a photo
- do not disturb the insect (this may be as simple as closing the doors on a shipping container or preventing access to an orchard)
- collect a sample, if it is safe to do so and if it doesn't disturb the insects.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/plant/identify/spongy-moth>